

FDA Name Differentiation Project

FDA List of Established Drug Names Recommended to Use Tall Man Lettering (TML)

Tall man lettering (TML) is a technique that uses uppercase lettering to help differentiate look-alike drug names. Starting on the left side of a drug name, TML highlights the differences between similar drug names by capitalizing dissimilar letters (e.g., vinBLASTine versus vinCRISTine and CISplatin versus CARBOplatin).¹ TML can be used along with color or bolding to draw attention to the dissimilarities between look-alike drug names, and alert healthcare providers that the drug name can be confused with another drug name.

In 2001, FDA initiated the name differentiation project to continually evaluate postmarketing reports of name pair confusion, and determine if TML should be used to help differentiate similar [established names](https://www.ecfr.gov/cgi-bin/retrieveECFR?gp=1&SID=1d3d3674a29049ca839676245268717e&ty=HTML&h=L&mc=true&r=SUBPART&n=sp21.4.299.a#se21.4.299.14) (<https://www.ecfr.gov/cgi-bin/retrieveECFR?gp=1&SID=1d3d3674a29049ca839676245268717e&ty=HTML&h=L&mc=true&r=SUBPART&n=sp21.4.299.a#se21.4.299.14>). The FDA evaluation considers multiple factors, including the degree of similarity between the name pair, safety risks with confusion between the name pair, overlapping product characteristics, reports of wrong drug errors, and causes or contributing factors. If FDA's evaluation determines TML is an appropriate approach to address reports of name confusion, FDA will request the manufacturer voluntarily revise their labels and labeling to use TML, and then update the FDA List of Established Drug Names Recommended to Use Tall Man Lettering. FDA may also consider labeling revisions, safety communications, and other approaches to address reports of product name confusion.

¹Institute for Safe Medication Practices. [Special edition: tall man lettering; ISMP updates its list of drug names with tall man letters](https://www.ismp.org/resources/special-edition-tall-man-lettering-ismmp-updates-its-list-drug-names-tall-man-letters) (<https://www.ismp.org/resources/special-edition-tall-man-lettering-ismmp-updates-its-list-drug-names-tall-man-letters>) [⌂](http://www.fda.gov/about-fda/website-policies/website-disclaimer) (<http://www.fda.gov/about-fda/website-policies/website-disclaimer>). 2016 Jun 2 [cited 2019 Aug 23].

The following is a list of the established drug names recommended to use tall man lettering:

Established Name	Recommended Name
Acetohexamide Acetazolamide	acetoHEXAMIDE acetaZOLAMIDE
Bupropion Buspirone	buPROPion busPIRone
Chlorpromazine Chlorpropamide	chlorproMAZINE chlorproPAMIDE
Cisplatin Carboplatin	CISplatin CARBOplatin
Clomiphene Clomipramine	clomiPHENE clomiPRAMINE
Cyclosporine Cycloserine	cycloSPORINE cycloSERINE
Daunorubicin Doxorubicin	DAUNOrubicin DOXOrubicin
Dimenhydrinate Diphenhydramine	dimenhyDRINATE diphenhydrAMINE
Dobutamine Dopamine	DOBUtamine DOPamine
Glipizide Glyburide	glipiZIDE glyBURIDE
Hydralazine Hydroxyzine	hydrALAZINE hydroXYzine
Hydromorphone	HYDROmorphone
Medroxyprogesterone Methylprednisolone Methyltestosterone	medroxyPROGESTERone methylIPREDNISolone methylTESTOSTERone
Methylprednisolone Methyltestosterone	methylIPREDNISolone methylTESTOSTERone
Migalastat Miglustat	migALAstat migLUstat
Mitoxantrone	mitoXANTRONE
Nicardipine Nifedipine	niCARDipine NIFEDipine
Prednisone Prednisolone	predniSONE prednisoLONE
Risperidone Ropinirole	risperiDONE rOPINIRole
Sulfadiazine Sulfisoxazole	sulfADIAZINE sulfISOXAZOLE
Tolazamide Tolbutamide	TOLAZamide TOLBUtamide
Trazodone Tramadol	traZODone traMADol
Vinblastine Vincristine	vinBLASTine vinCRISTine

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